INSTRUCTOR LESSON PLAN

Nobody Assigned This

Builds: Initiative / Self-Starting · (lightly touches Decomposition)

A turnkey unit for teaching students to start without being told and investigate before asking.

> **Builds:** Initiative / Self-Starting · (lightly touches Decomposition) **Grade band:** 6–12 (adaptation notes for grades 3–5 and college/CTE below) **Time:** 3 sessions of ~45 minutes, run as three iterations across a term (not three days in a row) **Format:** Whole-class launch with a teacher-provided menu → independent problem selection → fully self-started, no-prompt spotting by the third iteration

Why this unit

This is the question from the keynote that the workforce asks most and sees least. Maya can finish anything you start her on — the problem her boss has is whether she can *start*. Can she look at a problem nobody assigned her and decide to move on it? Our students are exceptionally good at waiting for the next instruction, because we have trained them to: the more we break work into tiny validated steps, the more we teach task-dependency. This unit deliberately does the opposite. It withholds the next step and makes the student generate it. It builds the muscle of spotting a real, unassigned problem, investigating it before raising a hand, and taking a small first action on your own. Initiative sits underneath every other durable skill — you cannot decompose, adapt, or persist on work you never began.

Learning objective

By the end of the third iteration, **students can spot an unassigned problem worth solving, investigate it before asking for help, propose a concrete next step, and take a small first action on their own** — without a teacher prompting them to begin.

Materials & prep

Teacher prep (~15 min the first time, ~3 min after):

- Build a short **menu of real, unassigned problems** drawn from your room, school, or community — things nobody currently owns. Keep them small and true: *"The recycling bins overflow by Thursday," "Newcomers can't find the library," "The class calendar is always out of date."* Keep a running bank of 6–8 so you can rotate them and retire the ones students solve.
- Post the **"Try three before you ask me"** norm somewhere permanent (see handout). Decide your three: re-read it, try a different approach, look it up. This norm is the engine of the whole unit.
- Print the **Student Handout** (below), one per student, or post it to your LMS.
- Be ready to *not* answer. Your hardest job is to withhold the next step. When a student arrives stuck, your first words are *"What have you tried, and what will you try next?"* — not the answer.

Students need: the handout, something to write with, and from iteration 2 on, a place to log what they tried before asking (a notebook margin, a sticky, an LMS field).

The arc at a glance

Session	Focus	~Time
1 — Spot	Choose an unassigned problem from the menu; learn the "try three before you ask" norm; take a first step with support	45 min
2 — Investigate	Pick a problem from a broad category; use the norm independently; propose a next step and take it	45 min
3 — Start cold	Surface your *own* unassigned problem with no prompt; investigate, propose options, act; self-assess	45 min

Step-by-step sequence

Session 1 — Spot and take the first step (45 min)

- **(5 min) Frame the rules.** Tell students plainly: *"Nobody is going to assign you today's problem. Your job is to pick one and move on it before anyone tells you to. And part of your grade is what you try before you raise your hand."* This permission is the whole move.
- **(10 min) Pick from the menu.** Post the menu of real unassigned problems. Each student (or pair) picks one that bugs them. Iteration 1 only: the menu does the spotting *for* them — that's intentional scaffolding.
- **(10 min) Model "try three before you ask."** Walk the class through the norm out loud on one menu problem: re-read what you know, try a different approach, look it up — *then* ask, and ask a precise question. Show them what "I'm stuck" sounds like rewritten as *"I tried X and Y, so my real question is Z."*
- **(15 min) Take a first step.** Each student names one concrete next step and actually does a small version of it right now — a three-line draft, a one-sentence email, a quick sketch of the bin layout, a five-minute count of how fast the recycling fills. Not a finished project. A *start*.
- **(5 min) Report the start.** Two or three students report: the problem, what they tried, and the first step they took. Collect everyone's first-step artifact.

Session 2 — Investigate before asking (45 min)

- **(5 min) Reset the norm.** No menu of exact problems this time — instead give a **broad category** ("something in this room wastes time," "something makes a new student's first day harder"). Students surface their own specific problem inside it.
- **(15 min) Investigate independently.** Students dig into their problem using "try three before you ask," and **log every attempt** before any hand goes up. When a student does ask, hold the line: *"What have you tried? What's your real question now?"* Refuse to give the next step.
- **(15 min) Propose and act.** Each student writes one concrete next step, then takes a small first action on their own — a draft, a message, a prototype, a tiny experiment. (Naming the *first* step before the rest is the Decomposition link — but the point here is moving, not planning.)
- **(10 min) Before/after debrief.** Each student reads their "I'm stuck" instinct next to the question they actually asked after trying three things. The gap *is* the lesson. Ask: *"What did investigating first change about what you needed from me?"*

Session 3 — Start cold (45 min) — *iteration 3 only, fully released*

- **(5 min) No menu, no category.** Tell students only: *"Find a problem nobody assigned you. Move on it."* No prompt, no list, no priming.
- **(25 min) Self-started submission.** Each student, on their own: names a problem they spotted, documents what they investigated, proposes more than one option, picks the most promising, and takes a first action — then writes down

what they'll try next.

- **(15 min) Self-assessment.** Students score themselves against the rubric language and against the norm they've been living. Collect both the work and the self-assessment.

Student handout (copy-ready)

> **Nobody Assigned This**
>
> Most of school waits for someone to tell you what to do next. This doesn't. Your job is to find a problem nobody handed you and *move on it* — and to investigate before you ask for help. Part of your grade is what you tried before you raised your hand.
>
> **Step 1 — Spot it.** Name one real, unassigned problem worth solving in this room, this school, or your community. ("The recycling overflows by Thursday." "Newcomers can't find the library.") *(Early on, your teacher gives you a menu. By the end, you find your own.)*
>
> **Step 2 — Try three before you ask.** Before any hand goes up:
>
> 1. Re-read / re-look at what you already know
> 2. Try a different approach
> 3. Look it up
>
> Write down what each try told you. *Then* — if you still need help — ask a precise question: *"I tried X and Y, so my real question is Z."*
>
> **Step 3 — Propose the next step.** Don't stop at "I'm stuck." Write at least one concrete next step. Later, write **two or three options** and pick the most promising.
>
> **Step 4 — Take a first action.** Actually do a small version of that step *right now* — a draft, a one-line email, a quick sketch, a five-minute experiment. Small and fast. This is about the *start*, not a finished project.
>
> **Step 5 — Report.** In one or two sentences: *"Here's what I tried, and here's what I'll try next."* That sentence is the whole skill.

What proficient looks like (teacher look-fors)

- The student **begins moving** on a problem before you tell them to — and on their own problem by iteration 3.
- "I'm stuck" is **replaced** by *"I tried X and Y, here's my real question."*
- The student **logs attempts** before asking, and the question that follows is **precise**.
- When stuck, the student **proposes a next step** and **takes a small first action** instead of waiting.

Assessment

Score with `toolkit/rubrics.md`, the Initiative / Self-Starting cluster, no separate grade required — lay it over the work students already produced:

- **Initiative / Self-Starting →** *"...start work without being prompted."*
- **Initiative / Self-Starting →** *"...investigate a problem before asking for help."*
- **Initiative / Self-Starting →** *"...propose a next step when stuck."*

Proficient = does it independently this time. **Advanced** = begins before the formal start, documents what was tried and frames a precise question, and generates multiple options and acts on the most promising one.

The rubric for this unit

Lay these competency rows over the work students already produced — no separate assignment. **Proficient** is the target (demonstrated and independent); **Advanced** means the student extends the skill unprompted.

Initiative / Self-Starting

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...start work without being prompted.	Sits idle after an assignment is given; waits to be told the specific next step before doing anything.	Gets started after a general nudge ("you should probably begin") but needs that nudge every session.	Opens the project and begins on their own, without a reminder, at the expected time or earlier.	Begins before the formal start, scopes what they don't know yet, and shares early drafts to surface issues fast.
...investigate a problem before asking for help.	Asks the first question that arises without attempting to find the answer independently.	Makes one attempt to find an answer, then asks immediately if it does not work.	Makes a genuine effort to investigate (tries a different approach, searches, re-reads) and then asks a specific, informed question.	Documents what was tried before asking, frames the question precisely, and proposes a hypothesis to test.
...propose a next step when stuck.	Reports being stuck and waits for the teacher to provide the next move.	Describes the problem but offers no idea for how to proceed.	Describes the problem and names at least one concrete thing to try next.	Generates multiple options, evaluates the trade-offs briefly, and acts on the most promising one.

Gradual release across the three iterations

	Teacher provides	Student provides
Iteration 1	A menu of problems; models "try three before you ask"; helps shape the first step	A first step with support
Iteration 2	A broad category only; holds the no-next-step line; no help until three tries are logged	A self-chosen problem, the norm used independently, a proposed next step taken
Iteration 3	Nothing — no menu, no category, no prompt	A self-spotted problem, investigation, multiple options, a first action, and a self-assessment

The goal is that by iteration 3, starting on an unassigned problem is *automatic*, not assigned — and the student arrives with *"here's what I tried and here's what I'll try next,"* not *"I'm stuck."*

Differentiation & adaptation

- **Grades 3–5:** Keep the menu concrete and visible ("the line at the pencil sharpener is too long"). Cut "try three" to "try two." Skip the multiple-options step; the win is taking *one* first action without being told.
- **College / CTE:** Pull problems from a real workplace, lab, or program of study, and require a brief written log of what was investigated and which sources or people were consulted before help was sought. Push hard on generating multiple options and defending the chosen one.
- **Multilingual learners / IEPs:** Provide sentence frames for the report-out (*"I tried ___ . It told me ___ . My next step is ___ ."*) and let "try three" be drawn or spoken rather than written. The frame scaffolds the form without naming the problem for them.
- **Time-crunched version:** Run only Session 1 as a single block at the start of any week. Spotting one menu problem and taking one first step already breaks the wait-for-instructions habit.

Common pitfalls

- **Answering instead of withholding.** The instant you supply the next step, you rebuild task-dependency. Always counter with *"What have you tried, and what will you try next?"* first.
- **Letting the deliverable grow.** This is about the *start*, not a finished project. If students are polishing, you've lost the point — keep the first action small and fast.
- **Spotting the problem for them too long.** The menu is a scaffold to withdraw. If you're still handing out the exact problem by iteration 3, the initiative never transfers.
- **Running the three sessions back-to-back.** The skill builds by *spacing* the iterations across a term so the scaffolding can actually withdraw.

The low-lift version (if you have no room for the full unit)

Adopt two standing rules in your room, no unit required. First: every help request must include a **"what I tried before I asked"** line — no line, no answer yet. Second, the **no-next-step rule**: when a student says *"I'm stuck,"* they must propose one thing to try before you respond. Those two moves are the Investigate-Before-Asking weave-in — the entire unit compressed into two sentences of classroom norm.